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SOC ANALYST LEVEL 1

MASTER ROADMAP — REDESIGNED, INDUSTRY-BENCHMARKED (TIER 1-4)

● R.D. College, Sheikhpura, Bihar — BCA Sem 2 ● SOC Analyst L1 (Blue Team) — India ● Estonia/EU L2 — Background Track ● All Links Tap-Ready

CANDIDATE	VERSION	WINDOW	SUPERSEDES
Shivam Kumar	v2.1 — Locked 12 mo	Aug 2026 – Aug 2027	V2 (July 2026)

LOCKED VERSION — DO NOT REBUILD FOR 12 MONTHS · All original resources retained · Styling/formatting redesigned only

LEVEL TAGS: SOC L1 = Level-1 triage skill · SOC L2 = Level-2 deep investigation / engineering · SOC L1 & L2 = useful for both

0 What Changed From v1 — Gap-Fix Log

#	Gap in v1	Fix in v2
1	No ArcSight / LogRhythm despite these appearing in most India SOC job postings alongside Splunk	Added ArcSight/LogRhythm concept-level coverage — Sec 3A
2	No named EDR/XDR brands (CrowdStrike, SentinelOne, MS Defender)	Added as a dedicated topic with free docs/demo trails — Sec 3B
3	No memory forensics tool	Added Volatility — Sec 3B
4	ISO 27001/PCI-DSS only tied to the Estonia track, not India	Added as India-context topic — Sec 3J
5	No CERT-In/RBI cyber framework awareness (needed for BFSI SOC roles)	Added — Sec 3J
6	No ticketing/case tool awareness (ServiceNow, Jira)	Added — Sec 3B
7	AI section was thin and not tied to specific free tools	Expanded into a full AI-SOC + Prompt Engineering track — Sec 4
8	Incorrect claim that TryHackMe had shut down	Removed; TryHackMe/HTB excluded entirely, no false reasoning attached
9	No salary/expectation reality check	Added — Sec 5F
10	Security+ knowledge pushed too late (post-job)	Full Security+ knowledge moved into Phase 2
11	No cloud hands-on, only “awareness”	Upgraded to light hands-on with AWS/Azure free tiers — Sec 7
12	No explicit company-tier mapping	Added — Sec 0.1

0.1 Industry Tier Alignment — Where This Roadmap Gets You

Tier	Example Employers	What v2 Covers For This Tier
TIER 1 Product/MNC GSOC	Large product security teams, elite MNC SOCs	Cloud SIEM (Sentinel) + CrowdStrike/Defender awareness + Sigma authorship + AI-copilot literacy + scripting
TIER 2 Large IT Services	TCS, Wipro, Infosys, Accenture Security, Tech Mahindra	Splunk + Sentinel + MITRE ATT&CK + ISO 27001 awareness + Event ID mastery
TIER 3 MSSPs (best fresher entry)	Sequretek, SISA, Aujas, NetEnrich, Paladion (Atos)	ArcSight concept + Splunk + AD attacks + 24x7 shift readiness
TIER 4 Small/local, startups	Regional system integrators, small product cos	Foundation + home lab + basic scripting — easiest entry point if Tier 2/3 apps are slow

1 Semester Map

Semester	Phase	Core Focus	Checkpoint
Sem 2 (NOW)	Phase 1	Networking + Linux + Windows + Git	GitHub live, picoCTF started
Sem 3	Phase 1	Fundamentals + CLI + Security+ knowledge begins	Cisco + IBM badge earned
Sem 4	Phase 2	SIEM (Splunk/Wazuh) + home lab	Lab built, Splunk+Wazuh live
Sem 4 (parallel)	AI-SOC Track	Prompt engineering + AI-copilot literacy begins	First AI-verification writeup
Sem 5	Phase 2	EDR + AD + Frameworks + India compliance + KQL/SPL	15+ writeups, CyberDefenders done
Sem 6	Phase 3	Portfolio + Resume + Job Prep	25+ writeups, resume+apps live
BCA +3 months	Phase 4	Applications across Tier 2/3/4	First SOC job
BCA +1–2 yrs	Phase 5	Threat hunting, detection engineering	Move toward Tier 1
BCA +3–4 yrs	Phase 5 (bg)	Estonia/EU L2 — awareness only	No action yet

2 Phase 1 — Foundation (Sem 2 → Sem 3)

2A. Core Topics

Topic	Resource	Access
SOC L1 & L2 OSI Model — 7 layers, where real attacks happen	Professor Messer Network+ N10-008	professormesser.com
SOC L1 & L2 TCP/IP — 3-way handshake, flags, headers	Professor Messer Network+	professormesser.com
SOC L1 & L2 DNS — resolution flow, records, poisoning concept	Professor Messer Network+	professormesser.com
SOC L1 & L2 HTTP/HTTPS — methods, status codes, TLS handshake	Professor Messer Network+	professormesser.com
SOC L1 & L2 Common ports (21,22,23,25,53,80,443,445,3389)	Professor Messer Network+	professormesser.com
SOC L1 & L2 IP + Subnetting, CIDR, NAT drills	subnetting.net	subnetting.net
SOC L1 & L2 Linux commands (cd, grep, find, chmod, ps, netstat, curl)	LinuxJourney	linuxjourney.com
SOC L1 Linux log locations (/var/log/auth.log, /var/log/syslog)	LinuxJourney + OverTheWire Bandit	overthewire.org
SOC L1 & L2 Windows basics — Users, Services, Event Viewer, Registry	Microsoft Learn	learn.microsoft.com
SOC L1 & L2 PowerShell basics — Get-Process, Get-Service, Get-EventLog	Microsoft Learn	learn.microsoft.com

2B. Git, GitHub & Security Concepts

Topic	Resource	Access
SOC L1 & L2 Git — init/add/commit/push/pull/clone/status/log	GitHub Skills	skills.github.com
SOC L1 & L2 Branching — branch, checkout, merge	Pro Git Book	git-scm.com
SOC L1 & L2 Repo hygiene — .gitignore, README, Markdown	Markdown Guide	markdownguide.org
SOC L1 & L2 Firewall types — packet-filter vs stateful vs NGFW	Professor Messer SY0-701	professormesser.com
SOC L1 IDS/IPS — signature vs anomaly (concept only)	Professor Messer SY0-701	professormesser.com
SOC L1 & L2 Hashing/Encryption — MD5/SHA256, symmetric/asymmetric, TLS	Professor Messer SY0-701	professormesser.com

SOC L1 & L2 Full Security+ (SY0-701) knowledge domain (exam paid/optional, knowledge free)	Professor Messer full playlist	youtube.com

2C. Practice Platforms

Topic	Resource	Access
SOC L1 Guided beginner CTF progression, free forever	picoCTF	picoctf.org
SOC L1 Self-directed Linux wargame practice	OverTheWire Bandit (Level 0–20+)	overthewire.org
SOC L1 Structured networking + Jr. Cyber Analyst path with badge	Cisco Skills For All	skillsforall.com
SOC L1 Cybersecurity Fundamentals badge	IBM SkillsBuild	skillsbuild.org
SOC L1 Free threat-landscape certificate	Fortinet NSE 1 & 2	fortinet.com
SOC L1 & L2 Automate the Boring Stuff — first Python chapters	automatetheboringstuff.com	automatetheboringstuff.com

⚠ **CAUTION — PHASE 1 SEMESTER-WISE READING ORDER**
Sem 2 (now): OSI Model, TCP/IP, DNS, HTTP/HTTPS, Common Ports, IP+Subnetting, Linux commands (2A) · Git/GitHub basics, Branching, Repo hygiene (2B) · Start picoCTF, OverTheWire Bandit, Cisco Skills For All (2C)
Sem 3: Windows basics, PowerShell basics (2A) · Firewall/IDS/IPS/Hashing concepts, full Security+ knowledge (2B) · Finish Bandit + picoCTF beginner track, IBM SkillsBuild, Fortinet NSE 1&2, Automate the Boring Stuff first chapters (2C)
Do not jump ahead to Phase 2 tools before this list is done — foundation gaps show up badly in SOC interviews.

3 Phase 2 — SOC Core Skills (Sem 4 → Sem 5)

3A. SIEM Platforms

Topic	Resource	Access
SOC L1 & L2 Splunk SPL — search, stats, eval, rex, dashboards	Splunk Free Training (Fundamentals 1)	splunk.com
SOC L1 & L2 Microsoft Sentinel — KQL, analytics rules, cloud SIEM	Microsoft Learn (SC-900/SC-200)	learn.microsoft.com
SOC L1 & L2 Wazuh — agent setup, rule alerting, MITRE mapping	Wazuh Documentation	documentation.wazuh.com
SOC L1 & L2 Self-hosted ELK (Docker) — unlimited practice	Elastic Guide	elastic.co
SOC L2 Security Onion — beginner-friendly all-in-one NSM/SIEM	Security Onion Solutions Docs	docs.securityonion.net
SOC L1 ArcSight / LogRhythm — concept-level only (no stable free CE)	Vendor docs + official demo walkthroughs	microfocus.com
NEW SOC L2 Suricata — real network IDS/IPS engine hands-on (bundled with Security Onion); matters for Tier 1/2 interviews since v2 covered IDS/IPS only as a concept	Suricata official docs	docs.suricata.io

3B. Essential SOC Tools

Topic	Resource	Access
SOC L1 & L2 Packet capture, PCAP analysis	Wireshark	wireshark.org
SOC L1 & L2 Advanced Windows logging	Sysmon (Microsoft Sysinternals)	learn.microsoft.com
SOC L1 Hash/URL/IP/domain reputation	VirusTotal	virustotal.com
SOC L1 Interactive malware sandbox	Any.Run (free tier)	any.run
SOC L1 & L2 Encoding/decoding, log manipulation	CyberChef	gchq.github.io
SOC L1 & L2 Incident case management	TheHive	strangebee.com
SOC L1 Safe URL scanning	URLScan.io	urlscan.io
SOC L1 Email header / SPF-DKIM-DMARC checks	MxToolbox	mxtoolbox.com
SOC L1 & L2 Malware hash/botnet intel	Abuse.ch Bazaar	bazaar.abuse.ch
SOC L1 & L2 Regex for log parsing	Regex101	regex101.com
SOC L1 & L2 Threat intel IOC pulses	AlienVault OTX	otx.alienvault.com
SOC L2 Memory forensics — process/handle/network artifacts from RAM	Volatility 3 (free, open-source)	github.com
SOC L1 & L2 EDR/XDR concept — how alerts surface from an agent	MS Defender for Endpoint docs	learn.microsoft.com
SOC L1 & L2 EDR concept (alternate vendor demo)	CrowdStrike Falcon docs	crowdstrike.com
SOC L1 & L2 EDR concept (alternate vendor demo)	SentinelOne resources	sentinelone.com
SOC L1 Ticketing/case workflow — how SOC handoffs happen	ServiceNow Developer instance	developer.servicenow.com
SOC L1 Ticketing/case workflow (alternate)	Atlassian Jira free tier	atlassian.com
NEW SOC L2 SOAR — automated playbooks; job postings increasingly mention SOAR alongside SIEM	Shuffle SOAR (self-hosted, free)	shuffler.io
NEW SOC L1 & L2 YARA rules — malware/file pattern matching, used alongside Sigma for detection engineering; a common SOC L1 interview topic	YARA official docs + VirusTotal YARA integration	virustotal.github.io
NEW SOC L1 Have I Been Pwned — breach/credential-exposure lookups, common first triage step for phishing/account-compromise alerts	haveibeenpwned.com	haveibeenpwned.com

3C. Windows Event IDs — 15 Must-Know SOC L1 & L2

ID	Meaning	Why It Matters	Priority
4624	Successful Logon	Baseline normal logins	Monitor
4625	Failed Logon	Brute force / spray	HIGH
4648	Explicit Credentials Logon	Pass-the-hash / lateral movement	HIGH
4672	Special Privileges Assigned	Admin activity tracking	HIGH
4688	Process Creation	Malware / suspicious chains	HIGH
4698	Scheduled Task Created	Attacker persistence	HIGH
4720	User Account Created	Unauthorized backdoor account	HIGH
4726	User Account Deleted	Post-attack cleanup	Monitor
4732	User Added to Security Group	Privilege escalation	CRITICAL
4740	Account Locked Out	Brute force confirmation	HIGH
4771	Kerberos Pre-Auth Failed	Kerberoasting indicator	HIGH
4776	NTLM Auth Attempt	Pass-the-hash indicator	HIGH
1102	Audit Log Cleared	Attacker covering tracks	CRITICAL
7045	New Service Installed	Malware persistence	HIGH
4104	PowerShell Script Block	Malicious PS command detection	HIGH

Resource: Microsoft Learn — Appendix L: Events to Monitor (official Security Audit Events reference) — **learn.microsoft.com**

3D. Threat Frameworks

Topic	Resource	Access
SOC L1 & L2 MITRE ATT&CK — 14 tactics, top 30 techniques, Navigator	attack.mitre.org	attack.mitre.org
SOC L1 & L2 Cyber Kill Chain — 7 stages	Lockheed Martin free PDF	lockheedmartin.com
SOC L1 & L2 NIST IR (SP 800-61) — 6 phases	NIST SP 800-61r2 PDF	nvlpubs.nist.gov
SOC L2 Diamond Model — Adversary/Capability/Infra/Victim	Original Caltagirone paper (Active Response)	apps.dtic.mil

3E. Active Directory & Identity SOC L1 & L2

AD structure (Domain/Forest/OU/DC) · Users, groups, permission inheritance · Kerberos TGT/TGS flow · Pass-the-Hash, Kerberoasting, DCSync · Azure AD/Entra ID basics · Key Event IDs: 4771, 4776, 4732, 4648.
Resource: Microsoft Learn — Active Directory Domain Services — **learn.microsoft.com**

3F. Programming / Scripting

Topic	Resource	Access
SOC L1 & L2 Python — #1 Must — log parsing, automation, API calls	Automate the Boring Stuff / freeCodeCamp	freecodecamp.org
SOC L1 & L2 Bash — #2 Must — log searching (grep/awk/sed)	LinuxJourney + Explainshell	explainshell.com
SOC L1 & L2 PowerShell — #3 Must — Windows queries	Microsoft Learn PowerShell	learn.microsoft.com
SOC L1 SQL (basic) — good to have — some SIEM backends use SQL	W3Schools SQL	w3schools.com

3G. Investigation Practice + Detection Engineering

SOC L1 **Phishing checklist:** Header (SPF/DKIM/DMARC) → sender domain whois → links via URLScan → attachment hash on VirusTotal → sandbox in Any.Run → extract IOCs → map to MITRE → document.
SOC L1 & L2 **Malware alert checklist:** Process + parent + command line → process tree → hash on VirusTotal → network connections → correlate Sysmon 1/3/13 → identify MITRE technique → timeline → escalate/close with reasoning.
SOC L2 **Write your own Sigma rule:** pick a real case from The DFIR Report, write one detection rule from it, post it on GitHub. This is your first real detection-engineering proof.

3H. Query Languages

Lang	Platform	Example	Resource
SPL SOC L1 & L2	Splunk	`index=main | search failed | stats count by src_ip | where count > 5`	Splunk Free Training
KQL SOC L1 & L2	Sentinel	`SecurityEvent | where EventID == 4625 | summarize count() by Account`	Microsoft Learn

3I. Verified Free Practice Platforms

Topic	Resource	Access
SOC L1 15 SOC alerts/month + Fundamentals/Phishing/Splunk courses	LetsDefend	letsdefend.io
SOC L1 & L2 PCAP, forensics, threat-hunting challenges	CyberDefenders	cyberdefenders.org
SOC L1 Weekly challenges, free tier	Blue Team Labs Online	blueteamlabs.online
SOC L1 Progressively harder guided CTF	picoCTF	picoctf.org
SOC L2 Real intrusion case studies	The DFIR Report	thedfirreport.com
SOC L2 3000+ detection rules to study/remix	Sigma HQ GitHub	github.com
SOC L1 & L2 Free whitepapers on SOC/IR/threat hunting	SANS Reading Room	sans.org

3J. India Compliance & Enterprise Context

Topic	Resource	Access
SOC L1 & L2 ISO 27001 — ISMS structure, why SOCs get audited against it	ISO 27001 free overview (27001 Academy)	advisera.com
SOC L1 & L2 PCI-DSS — why card-data environments get extra monitoring	PCI Security Standards document library	pcisecuritystandards.org
SOC L1 & L2 CERT-In guidelines — India's incident reporting rules	CERT-In official site	cert-in.org.in
SOC L1 & L2 RBI cybersecurity framework — relevant for BFSI SOC roles	RBI Cyber Security Framework in Banks	rbi.org.in

⚠ **CAUTION — PHASE 2 SEMESTER-WISE READING ORDER**
Sem 4: Home lab build (VirtualBox) · Splunk, Wazuh, self-hosted ELK, Security Onion + Suricata (3A) · Wireshark, Sysmon, VirusTotal, CyberChef, Volatility, ServiceNow/Jira awareness (3B) · Windows Event IDs — start memorizing the 15 (3C) · MITRE ATT&CK, Cyber Kill Chain (3D) · Python + Bash scripting (3F)
Sem 5: ArcSight/LogRhythm concept (3A) · Any.Run, TheHive, URLScan, MxToolbox, Abuse.ch, Regex101, OTX, EDR/XDR vendors, YARA, HIBP, Shuffle SOAR (3B) · NIST IR, Diamond Model (3D) · Active Directory & Identity (3E) · SQL basics (3F) · Investigation checklists + your first Sigma rule (3G) · SPL/KQL practice (3H) · LetsDefend, CyberDefenders, BTLO, DFIR Report, Sigma HQ, SANS (3I) · ISO 27001, PCI-DSS, CERT-In, RBI (3J)

4 AI-Powered SOC + Prompt Engineering

Full track — starts Sem 4, runs to job and beyond.

4A. Ground Reality

Automation platforms increasingly auto-triage and auto-close low-confidence false positives — pure “watch dashboard, click close” L1 work is shrinking. The analyst who can investigate deeply, write detections, and operate AI copilots stays valuable; the one who only clicks “close” doesn't. This is why this track sits parallel to Phase 2, not after it.

4B. Core AI-SOC Topics

Topic	Resource	Access
SOC L1 & L2 Prompt engineering fundamentals — zero-shot, few-shot, chain-of-thought	Anthropic Prompt Engineering Guide	docs.claude.com
SOC L1 & L2 Writing investigation-grade prompts	Practice against any free chat-AI tool with your own lab logs	docs.claude.com
SOC L1 & L2 AI-assisted log summarization & alert triage copilots	Microsoft Security Copilot docs	learn.microsoft.com
SOC L1 & L2 SIEM-native AI assistant (Splunk)	Splunk AI Assistant docs	docs.splunk.com
SOC L1 & L2 SIEM-native AI assistant (Elastic)	Elastic AI Assistant docs	elastic.co
SOC L1 & L2 Cloud-native AI SOC assistant	Google Security Operations — Gemini in Security	cloud.google.com
SOC L2 Agentic SOC / autonomous triage agents (2026 trend)	Vendor blogs: MS Copilot agents, CrowdStrike Charlotte AI	crowdstrike.com
SOC L2 LLM security risks — how attackers target AI systems	OWASP Top 10 for LLM Applications	owasp.org
SOC L1 & L2 Prompt injection awareness	OWASP LLM Top 10 (LLM01 section)	owasp.org
SOC L1 AI-generated phishing — breaks the old grammar heuristic	Proofpoint / KnowBe4 threat-intel blogs	knowbe4.com
NEW SOC L2 AI/ML-specific attack-technique framework — companion to MITRE ATT&CK for AI systems (model poisoning, prompt injection, data exfiltration via LLMs)	MITRE ATLAS	atlas.mitre.org

4C. Practical Exercise (do this monthly, minimum)

Whenever you get access to a free AI-security trial (Security Copilot demo, Splunk AI Assistant docs, Sentinel's Copilot for Security), run a real log/alert through it and write a short GitHub post: *"AI gave this output → I manually verified → here's what it missed/got wrong."* This single habit will separate your resume from most fresher applicants who only show manual triage skills.

⚠ **CAUTION — AI-SOC TRACK SEMESTER-WISE READING ORDER**
Sem 4 (parallel to Phase 2): Prompt engineering fundamentals, writing investigation-grade prompts (4B start)
Sem 5: Microsoft Security Copilot, Splunk AI Assistant, Elastic AI Assistant, Google Security Operations, agentic SOC vendor blogs, OWASP LLM Top 10, MITRE ATLAS, AI-generated phishing awareness (4B remaining)
Sem 4 → job (ongoing, monthly minimum): The AI-verification GitHub writeup habit (4C) — never skip a month once you start.

5 Phase 3 — Portfolio + Job Prep (Sem 5 → Sem 6)

5A. GitHub Portfolio Structure

SOC-Portfolio repo → 01-Networking-Notes / 02-Linux-Notes / 03-Log-Analysis / 04-Investigations / 05-SIEM-Queries / 06-Incident-Reports / 07-AISOC-Experiments. Each writeup: Scenario → Tools → Steps → Findings → IOCs → MITRE Technique → Lesson. Minimum 1/week → 25+ by final semester. Pin best 4–5.

5B. ATS-Friendly Resume

Section	Content
Summary	Aspiring SOC Analyst | Blue Team | BCA Final Year
Skills	Splunk, KQL/SPL, Wazuh, Wireshark, MITRE ATT&CK, Python, Bash, Windows Event IDs, ISO 27001 awareness, AI-copilot literacy
Certifications	Cisco badge, IBM badge, Fortinet NSE 1-3, SC-900, Splunk Fundamentals
Projects	GitHub portfolio link + top 2–3 writeups, including one AI-verification writeup
Education	BCA — year, college
Avoid	Fake certs, unverified skills, generic objective lines

5C. Scripting Portfolio Pieces

Script	Language	Folder
IOC checker (VirusTotal API)	Python	05-SIEM-Queries
Log parser (failed logins)	Python/Bash	03-Log-Analysis
Alert triage counter (4625 threshold)	PowerShell	03-Log-Analysis
Hash generator (MD5/SHA256)	Python	04-Investigations
Sigma rule (DFIR-inspired)	YAML	05-SIEM-Queries
AI-assisted log summarizer + manual-diff report	Python (free-tier LLM API)	07-AI-SOC-Experiments

5D. LinkedIn Strategy

Headline: *"Aspiring SOC Analyst | Blue Team | Cybersecurity Student."* Weekly share of a writeup. Badges visible. Connect with Indian SOC professionals/MSSP HR. Never exaggerate — SOC hiring verifies everything.

5E. Communication Practice — Daily

Technical writing (5 sentences/lab, 15 min/day) · English listening (Darknet Diaries, weekly) · Mock interview using the STAR method — record yourself, weekly · Alert explanation practice 5 min/day.

5F. Salary Reality Check (India, Fresher, 2026)

Scenario	Range
Fresher, no verified internship	₹3–5.5 LPA
Fresher, with a verified internship	₹5–8 LPA
Add one paid cert (Splunk Power User/Cisco CyberOps/BTL1)	Typically +₹1–2 LPA

⚠ **CAUTION — PHASE 3 SEMESTER-WISE READING ORDER**
Sem 5 (start early, parallel to Phase 2): Create the GitHub portfolio structure and begin weekly writeups now — don't wait for Sem 6 (5A)
Sem 6: ATS resume build (5B) · Finalize scripting portfolio pieces including the AI-assisted summarizer (5C) · Active LinkedIn strategy (5D) · Daily communication practice intensifies — STAR-format mock interviews (5E) · Salary reality check before you negotiate anything (5F)
25+ writeups is a Sem 6 target, not a last-week scramble — 1/week starting Sem 5 gets you there comfortably.

6 Phase 4 — Job Application (Final Sem + 3 Months After BCA)

Company Type	Examples	Search Term
MSSPs (best fresher entry — Tier 3)	Sequretek, SISA, Aujas, NetEnrich, Paladion (Atos)	"SOC Analyst Fresher MSSP India"
Large IT (Tier 2)	TCS, Wipro, Infosys, Accenture Security, Tech Mahindra	"Junior SOC Analyst [company]"
Product Security (Tier 1/2)	Quick Heal, K7, Seqrite, McAfee India, Trend Micro India	"Security Analyst Quick Heal K7"
Internships first	Any of the above + startups	"SOC Analyst Internship India"

Interview Categories

Category	Sample Question	Prep
SOC Basics	What is SOC? Tier 1 vs 2? Triage process?	Explain in your own words
Technical Tools	Find failed logins in Splunk? SYN scan in Wireshark?	Hands-on, not just theory
Scenario	"4625 spiking — what do you do?"	Logic, not memorization
Frameworks	MITRE basics? Kill Chain stages? T1566?	attack.mitre.org exploration
AI Literacy (new)	"How would you use an AI copilot during triage, and where would you NOT trust it?"	Your Section 4C writeups are your answer
Behavioral	Describe your best investigation	Real GitHub example, STAR format

⚠ **CAUTION — PHASE 4 TIMING**
Final Sem (Sem 6): Start applying to Tier 3 (MSSPs) and Tier 4 first — fastest fresher entry while you finish the degree
BCA +0–3 months: Widen to Tier 2 (large IT) and Tier 1/2 (product security) applications; keep applying to internships in parallel
Never pause BCA studies to chase applications early — Iron Rule #2 stays non-negotiable even here.

7 Cloud SOC Basics (2026 Onward) — Now With Light Hands-On

Topic	Resource	Access
SOC L1 & L2 SC-900 fundamentals (free, complete it)	Microsoft Learn SC-900	learn.microsoft.com
SOC L1 & L2 Microsoft Sentinel — KQL, analytics rules	Microsoft Sentinel docs	learn.microsoft.com
SOC L1 & L2 Azure Monitor / Log Analytics workspace basics	Microsoft Learn	learn.microsoft.com
SOC L2 AWS free-tier account: CloudTrail, generate + query events	AWS Free Tier	aws.amazon.com
SOC L2 Azure free trial — same exercise in Sentinel	Azure Free Account	azure.microsoft.com
NEW SOC L2 Official free AWS security hands-on labs — structured alternative/supplement to the free-tier CloudTrail exercise above	AWS SkillBuilder (free tier courses)	skillbuilder.aws

SOC L2 Cloud identity attacks — MFA bypass, service-account compromise — concept study alongside the hands-on labs above.

⚠ **CAUTION — CLOUD SOC SEMESTER-WISE READING ORDER**
Sem 5: SC-900 fundamentals, Microsoft Sentinel basics, Azure Monitor/Log Analytics concepts
Sem 6: Hands-on AWS free-tier CloudTrail exercise + AWS SkillBuilder labs, Azure free trial Sentinel exercise
Don't attempt the AWS/Azure hands-on before SC-900 concepts are clear — cloud logs make no sense without the fundamentals first.

8 Daily Routine

Time	Activity	Duration
Morning/College	BCA studies — non-negotiable	3–4 hrs
Afternoon	Cybersecurity theory/notes/video	1 hr
Evening	Hands-on labs (home lab/CyberDefenders/LetsDefend)	1–2 hrs
Evening	Lab writeup + GitHub commit	20–30 min
Anytime	Darknet Diaries + English practice	20–30 min
Weekend	Writeup polish + LinkedIn + community + DFIR/SANS reading + AI-SOC exercise	2–3 hrs

9 Phase 5 — After First SOC Job

SOC L2 Splunk/Sentinel deep dive — advanced queries, custom dashboards, alert tuning · Threat hunting — hypothesis-driven, not just alert response · Detection engineering — more Sigma rules, contribute upstream if possible · Learn to supervise, not just use, AI triage agents as they become standard tooling · Lead minor IR exercises · CompTIA CySA+ — start after 2 years · Keep reading The DFIR Report monthly.

10 Appendix — Estonia/EU Background (Awareness Only)

Unchanged from v1 — revisit only after 3–4 yrs India experience.

Point	Detail
Job Offer First	Non-EU citizens need a registered Estonian employer's offer before residence-permit process begins
2026 Trend	Rules tightening — strong India experience improves sponsorship odds
Salary Range	Roughly EUR 1,200–2,900/month; security analysts trend upper range
Schengen Benefit	Enables visa-free travel across 26 Schengen countries
Source Note	Verify with the Estonian embassy/PPA site directly before any real application — rules shift

10.1 EU-Track Resource & Timeline (Gap-Restored — was missing in v2.1 digitization)

Area	What To Do	Free Resource	Timeline
SOC Experience	Minimum 3–4 years genuine India experience first	—	After BCA +3–4 yrs
GDPR SOC L2	European data privacy — personal data, breach reporting	gdpr.eu	Year 2–3 of job
ISO 27001 SOC L1 & L2	Information security management — concept awareness	Search "ISO 27001 intro PDF"	Year 2–3 of job
English SOC L1 & L2	Professional-level English — Estonia operates in English	Darknet Diaries + BBC Learning English (see your English B2 Roadmap)	Start now (low priority)
CySA+ SOC L2	Best L2 cert for EU employers	Professor Messer YouTube	2–3 yrs into job

⚠ **CAUTION — PHASE 5 & APPENDIX TIMING**
Job +1–2 yrs: Deep-dive Splunk/Sentinel, threat hunting, detection engineering (Section 9)
Job +2 yrs: Start CompTIA CySA+ (Section 9) · Begin GDPR and ISO 27001 reading for the EU track (10.1)
Job +3–4 yrs: Only now revisit the Estonia/EU appendix for real action — not before (Section 10)
This whole Appendix is background awareness for right now — reading it early is fine, acting on it early is not.

11 Final Iron Rules v2 — Locked

1. This is v2.0 — locked for 12 months. Only checkbox progress and the 6-monthly link-health check get touched.
2. BCA degree comes first, always.
3. Every lab gets a writeup — no writeup, no portfolio credit.
4. Daily beats weekend-binge.
5. Hands-on beats videos.
6. Skills before certifications.
7. Practice English daily.
8. GitHub + LinkedIn 100% honest — SOC hiring verifies everything.
9. Home lab exposure is not optional anymore — expected baseline.
10. Always keep an investigation mindset — ask "why."
11. Never submit AI output unverified — this is your professional discipline, always.
12. Build community presence, not just applications.
13. Estonia planning stays fully parked until 3–4 yrs India experience.
14. TryHackMe and Hack The Box are intentionally excluded — do not add them back in.
15. Sequence never changes: Labs → Writeups → Portfolio → Applications.